

**THIS WAS
TOMORROW**
*IS THIS THE
FUTURE WE WERE
DREAMING OF?*

A PROJECT BY
ENRICO POLICARDO



Supported using public funding by
**ARTS COUNCIL
ENGLAND**

About the project

This Was Tomorrow: Is This the Future We Were Dreaming Of? is a long-term audio-visual investigation by artist and photographer Enrico Policardo into community-led housing across the UK - cohousing, Community Land Trusts, cooperative living, retrofit and repair.

It looks at places that are functioning in the present, without framing them as models or solutions. The question throughout is not "does this work?" but something closer to: what futures are still imaginable from where we are now?

The work began in 2022, with the fundamental input of Judith Martin, architectural historian and conservationist, documenting endangered council estates in London and the utopian ideals embedded in their material form. A residency at ESAD IDEA in Porto, made possible by the work of David Marques (Devity Studio), shifted the focus - from documenting the past to watching the present, and to how places actually function across different models of collective ownership, adaptation, repair, resilience and grassroots ingenuity.

The phase you are experiencing today reaches across England - from London and the south coast to Cornwall, and up into the North and West - with visits made during 2026, from March to July.

This work has been made possible by Arts Council England through the Developing Your Creative Practice (DYCP) scheme, and supported by Simon Vickery (Open House Festival Programme Manager), writer and photographer Thaddeus Zupancic (London Estates: Modernist Council Housing 1946-1981), and architectural historian Judith Martin, co-author of the original This Was Tomorrow publication.



ROPERS WALK

IS THIS THE FUTURE WE WERE DREAMING OF ?

Home-making

Home isn't only the physical roof and dwelling - it includes community, living well, and a vision of the future that isn't what I've come to define as the marry-mortgage-die structure. That isn't a criticism but an acknowledgement of what capitalism has done in nuclearising the family, creating false myths of independence, whether financial or of resources, all in favour of a system that is not built around the real needs, the needs of human beings, but around the needs of capital: the dehumanising idea of wealth that has been brought onto the main stage by centuries of elites pushing their own idea of what constitutes a good life. A life of belonging, and of having to defend it from hypothetical enemies.

The history of humanity - not the one written down in books, that one is the history of power, not the history of The People - says the opposite. People have always come together when facing practical challenges, hardships and obstacles, but also to celebrate, to procreate, and to feel a sense of belonging. That's what people have always done - not those surrounded by moats and crocodiles and the suffocating fear of losing their possessions.

It's just a field

Someone who put me in touch with one of the communities I visited told me "It's just a field, there's nothing to see". There was everything to see: an open ground where people could still decide what happens next. What a privilege to witness that. How many of you have been able to do so? To be somewhere where the soil is so rich that just by walking on it you feel nourished, enriched, more resilient than when you first arrived?

Care

Care and intelligence, choices made for the common good - not because I hold some high morality, but because the common good is the only thing that gives back without your having to ask whether it does. Made with the future in mind. Not for the now, but to keep future freedoms open rather than extracted.

This project, above all, is a reminder, mostly to myself. That we can. We're echo-systems: we rely and thrive on each other, on the reverberations we all generate, and we suffer from it too. Dreaming better futures isn't an idle process, an elitist indulgence in speculative horizons. Dreaming is the action that makes futures happen - or rather, that unlocks them.

The work goes outside, where everyone already is, and it's allowed to fade, wear

out, decompose, be forgotten. A vibrant orange turning into a pale yellow. Watching something fade is in itself an act of care, an acceptance of passing time. Things perish, and it's fine. We celebrate and embalm youth and feel bad when anything ages, dents or dims. In this fear there's the quintessence of the era we are living: the fear of losing, of missing out, of being replaced by someone or something faster, more efficient, more attractive, more hungry, more desperate.

Subtraction

I take the faces out of the recordings. I take the frame, the glass, the mount off the print and glue it to the wall.

Subtraction from the false perfection of a file - clean, inhuman, frictionless - and back toward the imperfection of the real world, which might be the only perfection there is. Bitmapping does this by misbehaving: the computer introduces its own noise and error, and never the same way twice, or so I like to believe.

I don't save the result. Every time I need a print I run the reduction again, and every run comes out differently, so no two prints have ever been the same and none can be repeated. It's the opposite of an edition: not one image copied many times, but one source that reinvents itself on every pass.

I like what the error finds: the grain, the wear, the things that don't resolve cleanly. When the result is partly out of my hands, it

takes away the burden of deciding everything. I don't much trust the idea that we author our own outcomes anyway.

People are not absent from this work - they're everywhere in it, digging the soil, foraging, planning, going to protests, dreaming.

They're just not inside the frame: they are around it.

This project is about imagination - about fuelling it - and imagination needs a gap to work in. Like reading: the words on the page are only a tool, and you supply the colours, the faces, the smells.

Enrico Policardo
Winchester, August 2026



A note from the artist

Making a project about future-
thinking and housing while living,
myself, inside that same question, is
the demonstration that this is not
speculatively, but concretely urgent
not only for myself and my family but
for many people out there.

My hope is that you walk away from
here not with faith, and not with some
Pandorian hope, but with the awareness
that a different future is not only
possible but it has already been made.

My deepest thanks go to all those who
have supported me throughout these
years and beyond, and who have made
possible not only this work but my
entire roaming existence. Above all, to
my partner Rosamond, for the unceasing
support she gives me on a daily basis.

Enrico Policardo, August 2026

MATERIALS

Curation Notes

On the wall

The prints are glued or hung directly, unframed. No glass, no mounts, no preciousness. If they wrinkle, fade or tear over the run of a show, that's part of it - the work is allowed to wear, the way anything does that lives in a real place rather than a vault. A framed print behind glass says this is valuable, keep back. This work says the opposite: it goes where people already are, in public and unconventional spaces rather than onto a clean white wall, and it's allowed to age in front of them. Watching something fade is an act of care and acceptance, not a fault to prevent.

For a sense of how this looks in practice - large images pasted unframed into public and institutional space - see the Branded Trash installations at www.enricopolicardo.com Cross-pollination is important for the project to make sense. No community sees only its own place hung in front of it - one site's images appear at another, and at a third. The point isn't to hand people proof of themselves; it's to let someone else's world land on them, so recognition arrives sideways. Keep this in mind when deciding which images go where: the pairing of image to venue is deliberate, not incidental. Ideally I'd like to be consulted on the curation before it reaches a final stage.

Sizes

Preferred print size is 100 x 140cm, scaling up only where a space genuinely calls for it. The space and the install method set the ceiling.

A note on the side of each image or other configuration

Pre-made A4 caption sheets to accompany the prints are provided with this document (below this section).

Each image should carry a small accompanying text next to it, explaining the bitmap - that what you're looking at is a map of bits, unique and unrepeatable, not a photograph in the ordinary sense.

How a show can work

It's a kit of parts, and it flexes to the space and the budget.

Simplest

A few big prints glued to a wall, a QR code beside them for the audio (<https://thiswastomorrow.co.uk/exhibition>). Nothing to plug in, nothing to break. This is my favourite.

Three channels kept apart

images on one wall or screen, the quotes on another (<https://thiswastomorrow.co.uk/quotes>), the audio on a third or via QR (<https://thiswastomorrow.co.uk/exhibition>). They're deliberately not synced, so nothing explains anything else and each visitor catches a different combination. The quotes are the interview content rendered as text rather than voice - not a transcript, but the substance is there - so someone who can't or won't use the audio still reaches what was said. It runs on a loop, so no one needs to man it.

You mix those to suit - prints only, prints plus a quotes screen, or the full three.

For install details and material tailored to your space, get in touch at info@enricopolicardo.com

Install

The install adapts to each venue rather than following one fixed method:

Where a wall can be used directly, prints are pasted straight on, unframed.

Where walls can't be marked, they are ideally hung from the ceiling and held down with a non-destructive weight, but left to their natural swing. Prints with a dowel top and bottom hang from the rafters on fishing line.

Outdoor and unconventional sites are preferred to gallery walls wherever the work and the weather allow.

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ENRICO POLICARDO Photographer and artist based in London. His work examines how systems of power organise everyday life, housing and who gets to shape it, waste and what a consumer economy throws away and the contested ground of borders. Creative Director of ReThinkable Festival on the Italy-Slovenia border (Nova Gorica / Gorizia, European Capital of Culture 2024-2026) and an Affiliate Research Fellow at the University of Nova Gorica.

This Was Tomorrow, supported by Arts Council England, documents communities across the UK who have taken housing into their own hands.

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